

Chicago Tribune



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SATURDAY, FEBRUARY 1, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



A HOLDING PATTERN FOR REGION'S HOMES

Chicago sales declined again in 2024. Will this year see more movement?

By Lizzie Kane | Chicago Tribune

Laura Hickman is ready to swap back the palmetto trees and cobblestone streets of Charleston, South Carolina, for the Chicago suburban lifestyle in which she and her kids grew up.

She put her downtown four-bedroom, single-family home on the market for a few months last year and said she only got “lowball” offers that she rejected. She never got the chance to bid on a home she liked in Chicago because she faced all-cash offers that caused the already limited inventory to fly off the shelves.

“We are waiting in Charleston for our house to sell, and ... nothing would sell here,” said Hickman, 59, who works in the finance department of a medical office. “It was quite the little mess.”

Hickman has listed her Charleston home again for \$1.5 million and is looking for a house between \$800,000 to \$1.2 million in the Chicago suburbs, where she thinks she will find more bang for her buck in terms of square footage.

Hickman’s story is one that unfolded for homebuyers and sellers across the Chicago-area market and the nation last year as mortgage rates and home

prices remained elevated. And her hope for better luck in 2025 is something shared by others involved in the real estate market.

Experts were optimistic for a busier real estate market last year after significant declines in home sales in 2023, but home sales in Chicago and statewide saw slight declines in 2024, according to Illinois Realtors, a trade association for real estate agents. Nationally, existing home sales, which exclude new construction homes, fell to the lowest levels in nearly 30 years for the second consecu-

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Andy and Heidi Graham, above, prepare dinner at home as their dog, Sloane, watches in Arlington Heights on Jan. 23. The couple, whose two grown children no longer live with them, own properties in Chicago and plan to eventually sell them, depending on the movement of the real estate market. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Trump pulling lever on tariffs

Levies to hit goods from Canada, Mexico, China

By Zeke Miller, Aamer Madhani and Josh Boak
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — President Donald Trump said Friday that he would place 25% tariffs on imports from Canada and Mexico and 10% tariffs on goods from China effective Saturday, raising the specter of swift price increases for U.S. consumers even though he suggested he would try to blunt the impact on oil imports.

Trump had been threatening the tariffs to ensure greater cooperation from the countries on stopping illegal immigration and the smuggling of chemicals used for fentanyl, but he has also pledged to use tariffs to boost domestic manufacturing and raise revenues for the federal government.

“Starting tomorrow, those tariffs will be in place,” White House press secretary Karoline Leavitt told reporters. “These are promises made and promises kept by the president.”

Shortly after Leavitt spoke, the S&P 500 stock index, the Nasdaq composite and the Dow Jones Industrial Average all sold off, largely erasing gains on the day.

The tariffs carry both political and economic risks for Trump, who is just two weeks into his second term. Many voters backed the Republican on the promise that he could tamp down inflation, but the possibility of tariffs could trigger higher prices and potentially disrupt the energy, auto, lumber and agricultural sectors.

Trump also drew fire for starting a trade fight with U.S. neighbors and allies Canada and Mexico as well as geopolitical rival China.

“We should be focused on going hard against competitors who rig the game, like China, rather than attacking our allies,” said Democratic Senate Leader

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Illinois eighth graders stack up nationally

Students outperform all but one state in math, reading

By Ikram Mohamed and Rebecca Johnson
Chicago Tribune

While officials at the U.S. Department of Education expressed concern with results of the “Nation’s Report Card,” noting that it depicts a “heartbreaking reality,” Gov. JB Pritzker and the Illinois State Board of

Education expressed excitement.

That’s because Illinois eighth graders outperformed the national average in math and reading, according to the 2024 National Assessment of Educational Progress results released Wednesday. Topping off the achievement, third through eighth graders showed the highest English proficiency rate to date, which, according to Pritzker, is “a testament to the great strides Illinois students are making academically,” the governor said in a news release.

Given every two years, the National

Assessment of Educational Progress, also known as the Nation’s Report Card, is considered one of the best gauges of the academic progress of the U.S. school system. The most recent exam was administered in early 2024 in every state, testing fourth- and eighth grade students on math and reading.

“Illinois students are proving what we’ve always known — when we support our schools, our kids thrive,” Pritzker said in the

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INSIDE Go-to inflation gauge up 2.6% in December

An inflation gauge closely watched by the Federal Reserve rose slightly last month, while some underlying price pressures showed signs of easing. But President Donald Trump’s import taxes on goods from Canada, China and Mexico potentially affect everything from autos to avocados, which could push prices higher in the coming months. **Business**

Elgin police turn to podcast for help solving ’83 cold case

True crime genre takes turn with a ‘real-time approach’

By Gloria Casas
Chicago Tribune

The last time anyone can remember seeing Karen Schepers, the 23-year-old Elgin woman was leaving a Carpentersville bar where she’d been attending a celebration with co-workers in 1983.

Her car was never seen again. Her bank account money remained untouched, credit cards unused and possessions abandoned.

Is she still alive, having deliberately abandoned her old life for a new one, as some people do? Did she accidentally drive into a pond on her way home, or maybe she met some more sinister fate.

More than four decades later, Elgin

police still don’t know. They’re hoping a new look at an old case via their 13-part podcast “Somebody Knows Something” might trigger a forgotten detail or lost memory that could help close the books on the mystery.

“One of the things we looked at was there is really no definitive (answer) of what happened to her,” Detective Matt Vartanian said. “We don’t know if it’s a homicide. We don’t know if she did something to herself. ... There are so many layers of possibilities.

“We want to be able to get it out there because we don’t know,” he said. “Somebody does know something.”

Vartanian and Detective Andrew Houghton make up the Elgin Police Department’s Cold Case Unit, which was

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CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

January ends with a grate escape

A woman uses a broom to clear debris from a sewer grate as street flooding developed at Damen and Leland avenues in Chicago’s Lincoln Square neighborhood following rain on Friday. A slight flood risk remains outside of the city, too, according to the National Weather Service, as recent above-average temperatures and heavy rainfall may lead to the breakup of ice jams in rivers and streams.

